

GST 112

Nigerian Peoples and Culture

Full Course Summary & Study Notes

This document summarizes all 11 core modules of GST 112, covering pre-colonial Nigeria, culture, heritage, colonial rule, nationalism, nation-building, government, citizenship, ethnicity, national ethics, and trade/self-reliance.

Module 1: Nigeria Before 1800

Before European contact, "Nigeria" did not exist as a single entity — it was a patchwork of independent kingdoms, empires, and stateless societies, each with its own government, economy, and belief system.

The Hausa (North)

Organized into city-states (Kano, Katsina, Zaria, etc.) ruled by an Emir who held both political and spiritual authority. Islam spread from around the 11th century and shaped law and governance.

The Yoruba (Southwest) — the Oyo Empire

One of the most sophisticated pre-colonial systems, built on a structure of checks and balances:

- **Alafin** — the king, seen as semi-divine
- **Oyo-Mesi** — a council of chiefs (headed by the Bashorun) that checked the Alafin's power; could compel an unpopular Alafin to step down
- **Ogboni cult** — a religious-political body enforcing customary law and mediating between the Alafin and Oyo-Mesi

The Igbo (Southeast)

Famously stateless/decentralized — no kings or central empire. Governance ran through age-grades (each with defined responsibilities), titled men (e.g. the ozo title, merit-based not birth-based), village councils, and the moral authority of the earth deity Ala. Often described as one of the most democratic pre-colonial systems in Africa, though the system varied by town.

Minority Groups

Kanuri, Fulani, Bini/Edo (Benin Kingdom), Tiv, Ijaw, Idoma, Igala, Jukun, Efik, Ibibio, Nupe, and many others — over 500 languages across Nigeria's ethnic groups.

Note: This centralized-vs-decentralized contrast becomes critical in Module 4: it explains why Indirect Rule worked smoothly in the North, less well in the West, and failed in the East.

Module 2: Culture — Meaning, Functions, Features, Types, Elements

Definition

Culture is the totality of a people's way of life — beliefs, values, norms, language, art, technology, food, dress, religion, and social institutions. It is **learned** through socialization, not inherited biologically.

Functions of Culture

- Identity
- Social control (norms/taboo regulate behaviour)
- Unity/cohesion
- Continuity (passing knowledge across generations)
- Adaptation to environment

Features of Culture

- Learned, not biological
- Shared collectively
- Dynamic (changes over time)
- Cumulative (builds on the past)
- Symbolic (meaning attached to objects/gestures/words)

Types of Culture

- **Material culture** — tangible: tools, clothing, buildings, art, food
- **Non-material culture** — intangible: beliefs, values, language, norms, religion

Characteristics

- Varies from society to society (relativity)
- Satisfies human needs
- Integrated — its parts (religion, economy, politics) reinforce each other

Elements of Culture

Language, religion, values, norms, symbols, customs, art, technology, and social institutions (family, marriage, government).

Note: Value = the abstract belief (why). Norm = the concrete rule that flows from it (how). E.g. value: respect for elders → norm: kneeling/prostrating to greet them.

Module 3: Nigerian Heritages and Cultural Policy

Sources of Nigerian Heritage

- Oral tradition — folktales, proverbs, myths, praise poetry
- Archaeology/artifacts — Nok terracotta figures (~1500 BC–500 AD), Benin bronzes, Ife bronze/terracotta heads
- Written records — colonial and missionary accounts, indigenous scholarship
- Religion and festivals as carriers of history and values
- Institutions — chieftaincy, age-grades, family structures

Preservation Methods

- Museums and monuments
- Documentation of oral traditions
- Education in indigenous languages/history
- Active festivals, not just recorded ones

Challenges to Preservation

- Westernization/globalization eroding youth interest (language loss → practice abandonment → belief change)
- Religious conflict — some faiths label traditional practices as "fetish"
- Loss of elder oral custodians

- Looting/theft (e.g. Benin Bronzes still held abroad)
- Inadequate funding for museums/archives
- Rural-urban migration disconnecting youth from roots

Cultural Policy of Nigeria (1988 National Policy on Culture)

- Promote national unity through diversity
- Preserve, protect and promote heritage
- Use culture as a tool for education and moral orientation
- Encourage cultural industries (arts, crafts, tourism) as economic assets
- Project a positive Nigerian image internationally

Module 4: Nigeria Under Colonial Rule

Advent of Colonial Rule

Portuguese traders arrived on the coast from the 15th century. British interest intensified in the 1800s after abolishing its own slave trade (1807), shifting to "legitimate trade" (palm oil, etc.). The Royal Niger Company (chartered 1886) administered trade and territory before direct British government control began around 1900, focused on exploiting Nigeria's resources for Britain's benefit.

Indirect Rule (Lord Lugard)

Governing through existing traditional rulers rather than replacing them with British officials.

- **North:** worked smoothly — centralized Emirate system was easy to co-opt
- **West:** worked moderately — Obas existed but power was checked by the Oyo-Mesi/Ogboni
- **East:** largely failed — no centralized chieftaincy among the Igbo, so the British invented "**warrant chiefs**" with no traditional legitimacy, causing deep resentment (e.g. the 1929 Aba Women's Riots)

The Colonial Economy

Designed to supply raw materials to Britain and serve as a market for British manufactured goods, producing unbalanced growth. Railways were built to export cash crops while food-crop production was neglected; mining was dominated by European companies whose profits went to Europe. This stunted industrial development and locked Nigeria into economic dependency.

Amalgamation (1914)

Lord Lugard merged the Northern and Southern Protectorates into one "Nigeria" — an administrative/economic convenience for Britain (the North ran a deficit, the South a surplus), not a reflection of shared Nigerian identity. Widely cited as the root of later ethnic/regional tension.

Module 5: Evolution of Nigeria as a Political Unit — Nationalism & Independence

Rise of Nationalism

- Western education produced an educated elite exposed to ideas of self-determination

- Economic grievances — unfair taxation, exclusion from economic power
- Pan-Africanism (Garvey, Du Bois) influencing elite thought
- WWII veterans questioning colonial rule after fighting for others' freedom
- Nationalist press (Macaulay's Lagos Daily News, Azikiwe's West African Pikin)

Key Parties and Figures

- **Herbert Macaulay** — "father of Nigerian nationalism"; founded the NNDP
- **NCNC** — Nnamdi Azikiwe; became associated with the East
- **Action Group (AG)** — Obafemi Awolowo; based in the West
- **NPC** — Ahmadu Bello; based in the North

Nationalism, which began as a shared anti-colonial cause, gradually regionalized along North/West/East lines — the same divisions inherited from amalgamation resurfaced once the shared external enemy (colonial rule) was removed.

Independence

Nigeria gained independence on October 1, 1960, with a federal system, an elected Prime Minister (Tafawa Balewa), and a ceremonial Head of State. Nnamdi Azikiwe became ceremonial President when Nigeria became a republic in 1963.

Module 6: Challenges of Nation-Building

First Republic Instability (1960–1966)

Three regions competed for power and resources, each dominated by one major party/ethnic group. The 1965 Western Region election crisis, widely seen as rigged, triggered widespread violence.

Coups and the Civil War

- **Jan 15, 1966:** Mostly Igbo officers overthrew the government; PM Tafawa Balewa and other leaders (mainly Northern/Western) killed. Gen. Aguiyi-Ironsi (Igbo) became Head of State — many in the North viewed it as an ethnic power grab.
- **July 1966:** Northern officers staged a counter-coup, killed Ironsi, installed Yakubu Gowon — followed by massacres of Igbo people in the North, triggering a mass exodus to the East.
- **1967–1970 Civil War (Biafran War):** The East, led by Odumegwu Ojukwu, declared the independent Republic of Biafra (May 1967). Federal forces under Gowon fought under the slogan "To keep Nigeria one is a task that must be done." The war caused a devastating famine, drawing international attention, and ended in January 1970 with Biafra's surrender.
- **Aftermath:** Gowon's reconciliation policy — "No victor, no vanquished."

Continued Military Rule

Nigeria cycled through further coups and military governments (Murtala Mohammed, Obasanjo, Buhari 1983, Babangida 1985, Abacha 1993) before a lasting return to civilian democracy in 1999 — a repeated pattern rooted in unresolved regional/ethnic tensions from amalgamation.

Module 7: Organs of Government

The Legislature

Bicameral National Assembly: Senate (109 members) and House of Representatives (360 members); unicameral State Houses of Assembly. Functions: law-making, budget approval, oversight of the executive.

The Executive

Headed by the President (federal) and Governors (state), assisted by ministers/commissioners. Functions: administration, foreign policy, defense, implementing programs, appointments.

The Judiciary — Court Hierarchy (lowest to highest)

- Magistrate / District Courts — minor civil and criminal cases
- High Courts (State and Federal) — more serious cases
- Court of Appeal — hears appeals from High Courts and specialized courts
- Supreme Court — final court of appeal

Plus specialized courts: Sharia Courts of Appeal (Islamic personal law, mainly North) and Customary Courts of Appeal.

Functions of the Judiciary

- Interpreting the constitution and laws
- Settling disputes (individuals, and individuals vs. the state)
- Protecting fundamental human rights
- Checking the Executive and Legislature (judicial review)
- Upholding the rule of law

Judiciary and Social Justice — Reflections

In theory, the judiciary is an impartial check guaranteeing equal treatment. In practice, challenges include corruption/political interference, case backlogs, unequal access to legal representation, and executive non-compliance with court rulings. Exam answers should weigh both the ideal role and the practical gap.

Module 8: Citizenship and Civic Responsibilities

Citizenship Acquisition

- By birth (descent)
- By registration (e.g. spouses of Nigerian citizens)
- By naturalization (residency requirements, good character, means of livelihood)

Fundamental Human Rights (1999 Constitution, Chapter IV)

Right to life, dignity of the person, personal liberty, fair hearing, freedom of thought/conscience/religion, freedom of expression, freedom of movement, freedom from discrimination, right to own property.

Civic Responsibilities

- Obeying the law

- Paying taxes
- Voting and political participation
- Respecting others' rights
- Protecting public property/environment
- Loyalty and national defense
- Community development participation

Problems of Citizenship and National Identity

- **Indigene vs. settler conflict** — a person can be born and raised in one state yet treated as an outsider there for jobs, admissions, or political appointments because their ethnic origin lies elsewhere; institutionalizes ethnic favoritism over residence
- Statelessness/documentation gaps
- Ethnic/religious identity often outweighing national identity
- Weak civic education

Module 9: Ethnicity and National Integration

Key Concepts

- **Ethnicity** — shared identity based on common ancestry, language, culture, or history
- **Ethnocentrism** — judging other cultures by the standards of one's own
- **National integration** — unifying diverse groups into a cohesive nation with loyalty to the state above ethnic loyalty

Causes of Ethnic Tension

- Artificial amalgamation (no organic pre-existing unity)
- Competition for political power/resources
- The indigene/settler policy
- Uneven distribution of federal appointments/resources
- Religious differences overlapping ethnic/regional lines
- Colonial favoritism creating unequal development

Government Integration Strategies

- **Federal Character Principle** — federal appointments/admissions must reflect Nigeria's diversity (debated: inclusion vs. merit)
- **State creation** — from 3 regions to 36 states, reducing dominance of the "big three" groups
- **NYSC** — graduates serve a year outside their home state to build cross-cultural bonds; effective in fostering friendships/intermarriages, but limited by language barriers, poor amenities in rural postings, and insecurity (banditry, kidnapping)
- **Federal Unity Colleges** — secondary schools deliberately mixing students from different states
- **Rotational power arrangements** — informal zoning of the presidency between North/South

Module 10: National Ethics, Values, and Re-orientation Strategies

National Ethics

Official moral principles Nigeria upholds: discipline, integrity, dignity of labour, social justice, religious tolerance, self-reliance, patriotism.

Negative Behaviours / Social Vices

- Cultism
- Corruption
- Examination malpractice
- General indiscipline
- Get-rich-quick mentality

Re-orientation Strategies

- **WAI** (War Against Indiscipline) — 1980s Buhari-era campaign for public discipline
- **MAMSER** — Babangida-era civic re-orientation agency
- **NOA** (National Orientation Agency) — current body shaping public values
- **EFCC / ICPC** — anti-corruption enforcement agencies

Current Socio-Political and Cultural Developments

Ongoing insecurity, agitation for restructuring/resource control, youth-led movements (e.g. #EndSARS), and continued tension between ethnic and national identity.

Module 11: Trade and Economic Self-Reliance

Indigenous Trade and Market Systems

Pre-colonial Nigeria had sophisticated trade networks — trans-Saharan routes in the North, riverine trade in the Niger Delta, and regional markets. Trading was widespread, with the Igbo especially known as prominent traders, linked to their decentralized political structure (Module 1) where trade became a major avenue for individual status.

Indigenous Apprenticeship System

The Igba-boi system (especially among the Igbo): a young person works under a master trader for years, then is "settled" with capital or goods to start their own business — a homegrown model of skill transfer and entrepreneurship.

Trade, Skill Acquisition, and Self-Reliance

The course frames reviving indigenous apprenticeship and trade skills as a practical solution to unemployment and an alternative to white-collar job dependency.

The single connecting thread across GST 112: Nigeria is a nation whose peoples had distinct, independent cultures and political systems before 1800; colonial rule (indirect rule, amalgamation, an extractive economy) forced these differences into one artificial state without resolving them; and everything since — nationalism splitting along regional lines, coups, civil war, the structure of government, citizenship conflicts, and ethnic tension — flows from that unresolved gap between imposed political unity

and genuine cultural/national integration, which government policy and civic re-orientation continue trying to close.